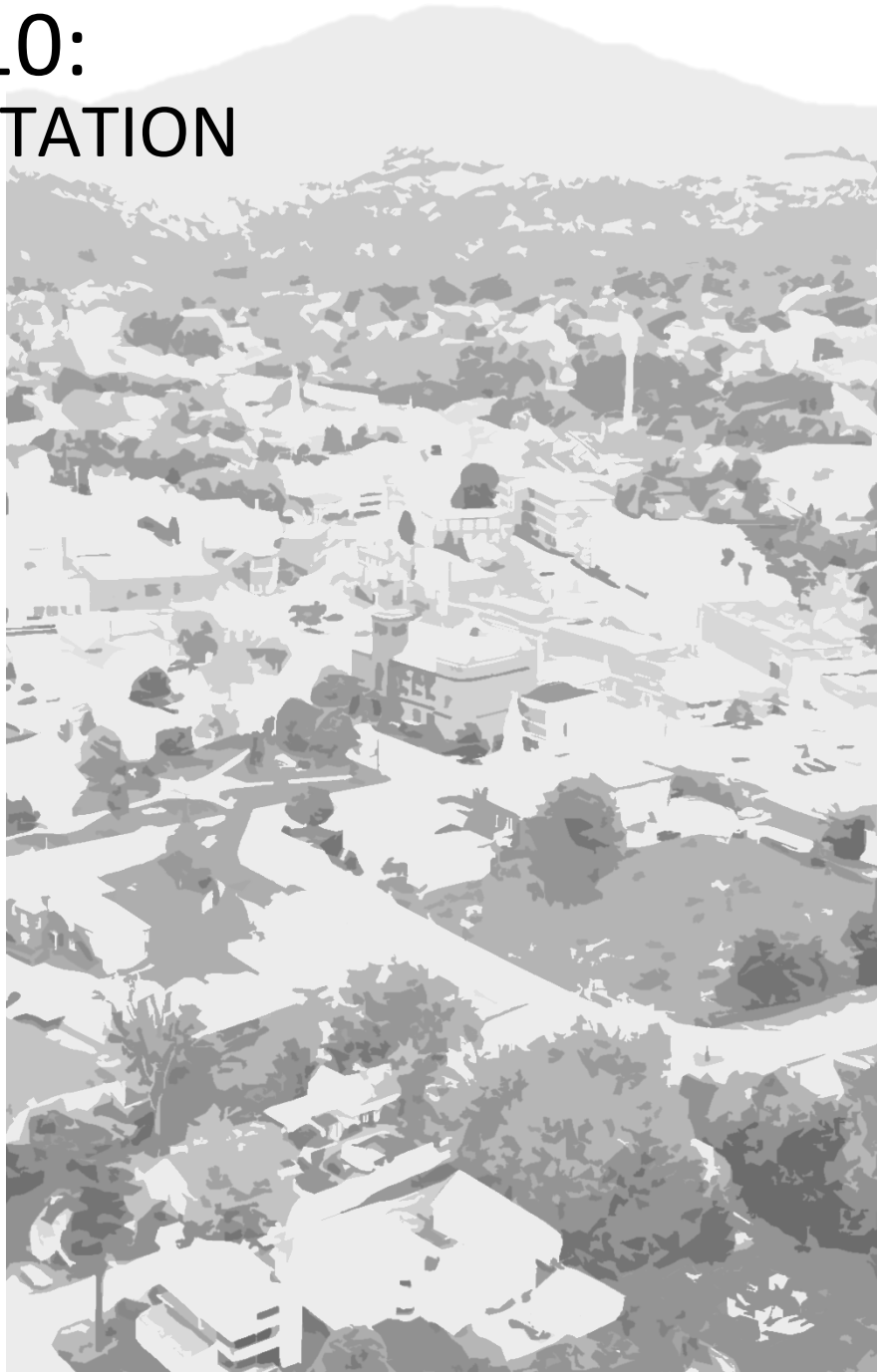


CITY OF CLAREMONT MASTER PLAN 2017

CHAPTER 10: TRANSPORTATION

Prepared by the
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and the
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Chapter 10: Transportation

Vision

By providing a safe, well-maintained system of roads, sidewalks and alternative transportation modes Claremont can foster the growth and development of infrastructure that is adequate for all users. Through the thoughtful development of the road network, Claremont will enhance the built environment welcoming further improvement and development. Additionally, this would provide an easily navigable network for residents, employees, and visitors alike.

Introduction

A good transportation system is essential to provide the citizens of Claremont a quality of life that meets their aspirations. To meet this standard the transportation system must be easy to use by the public, provide for the safety of the community, support its economic engine, and allow various forms of transit (e.g. buses and taxis) both locally and regionally.

A transportation system includes forms of infrastructure that enables various modes of travel including (but not limited to) walking, biking, on-road and off-road vehicles, trains, airplanes, and boats. Such infrastructure may include roads, rails, bicycle paths, parking, sidewalks, crosswalks, curb cuts, traffic lights and signs, intersections, airports, boat launches, and hiking trails. Developing the transportation system as a community resource is critical to

provide opportunities for improved lifestyle and promote economic development. It will be critically important for Claremont's transportation system to meet the growing demands of the City's population, commercial, and industrial development in order to promote the community's overall quality of life and support it as an economic center.

Improvements since the 2011 Master Plan include increased road maintenance, new passenger amenities at the Amtrak Station, improvements at the Claremont Municipal Airport, development of additional public parking, directional and parking signs, expanded bus routes, and substantial trail improvements.

Existing Conditions

The City of Claremont is served by a network of local roads that interconnect with state



routes to afford Claremont easy, regional connectivity. The state routes in Claremont serve as the major east-west and north-south connectors, not only for Claremont but for surrounding communities. NH Route 12/103 connects Claremont to Vermont and I-91 in the west, Route 11/103 to Newport and points beyond in the east, and Route 11/12 to Keene in the south. NH Route 120 begins in Claremont and travels north to connect Claremont to the City of Lebanon and Town of Hanover and their large employers. Additionally, Route 12A travels north along the western side of the City providing a corridor to the central Upper Valley. The road network in Claremont covers approximately 126 miles of road (both paved and gravel surfaces) on 320 streets and 35 miles of sidewalks.

The network of local roads not only provides access for motorists to connect to Claremont services, but in much of the downtown area, includes sidewalks for pedestrians and parking amenities. Claremont is also served by Amtrak service on the Vermonter line. The Claremont Municipal Airport serves a vital role in local business travel and delivery services.

Attached to this chapter you will find a complete copy of the 78 traffic count locations in Claremont. The New Hampshire Department of Transportation (NH DOT) collects data at each location every three years. Attached Table A. Washington Street north of Moody Avenue has the highest daily traffic in Claremont at a total of 20,000 cars per day. The second busiest location in Claremont is Broad Street north of Water Street at 18,000 cars per day. Each of these locations saw a decline of 2,000 cars per day from three years prior when data was collected in the same location. However, this fluctuation is not significant enough to cause concern and is within the typical fluctuation of traffic volumes throughout the City. The traffic volume table, Table A, shows that traffic volumes have stayed relatively level over the last decade, with small fluctuations both up and down in the number of cars per day. Table B details the roads, sidewalks and bridges in Claremont that are in critical need of service.

Goals

Claremont should annually plan to improve on all transportation resources so that steady progress is achieved. This chapter will focus on recommendations for Claremont to improve the overall transportation system and implement short-term and long-term planning to support future improvements.

The goals & objectives that follow are intended to provide a map to meet the challenges for the City's future and satisfy the preferences expressed in the survey of citizens for the Master Plan. The ultimate goal is to continue to maintain and/or improve the quality of Claremont's transportation network to make Claremont a great place to live, work and play.

Goal 1. Maintain adequate parking facilities accessible to the downtown business district.

1. Develop a program to provide overnight parking for residential tenants of downtown buildings so that those buildings may be profitably developed and their value increased.
2. Build additional safe and cost-effective parking to accommodate more workers, students, visitors and residents to the downtown using a coordinated and long-term approach.

3. Encourage schools to maintain appropriate parking due to fluctuating student levels while monitoring safety and security concerns.
4. Develop a regular maintenance program of public parking lots including consideration of establishing new tree plantings and greenspaces, and innovative stormwater management techniques.
5. Development review of new or existing private parking lots shall evaluate opportunity to incorporate tree plantings, innovative stormwater management techniques and impacts upon neighborhood aesthetics.
6. Provide year-round enforcement of downtown parking regulations. Provide adequate signage to identify public parking facilities and their corresponding time limits, with a standardized sign design for all public parking.
7. Develop public outreach materials advertising the available public parking in the downtown area as only 20% of parking during the parking study was occupied.
8. Educate downtown businesses about downtown parking and to monitor the parking of their employees and patrons to stay within the parking time limits.
9. Review layout of parking and curb cuts on Broad Street to increase sightlines for cars making left turns and make recommendations.
10. Encourage the efficient removal of snow from the downtown following snow events to maintain the number of parking spaces available.
11. Encourage the City to undertake a study to analyze the feasibility and cost benefit of parking meters and/or other methods.
12. Enhance the shared parking regulation for businesses/residences with complimentary parking needs. (i.e. one needs daytime parking and one needs overnight/weekend parking).
13. Develop a Downtown Parking Plan to incorporate and improve upon the above objectives.

Goal 2. Increase the use, appearance, and importance of the Claremont Municipal Airport and the Amtrak Station.

1. Plan for expanded use of the Amtrak Station to a medium-sized station (more than 4,000 passengers per year) by 2020.
2. Continue to improve the physical buildings and infrastructure of the Claremont Municipal Airport.
3. Continue to develop resources to make the airport a more valuable private aviation facility that can meet the needs of businesses and residents through the development of hangars and associated services such as aviation fuel and maintenance facilities.
4. Promote the increase in connectivity between the airport, Amtrak Station and downtown areas through the availability of taxis services, rental cars, and pedestrian/bicycle amenities.
5. Encourage the use of the airport and Amtrak Station through the development of complementary businesses in the area of the airport and train station.



6. Add information/tourism signage, including “you are here” type signage and online resources.

Goal 3. Develop bicycle, hiking and recreational vehicle routes.

As roads are repaved or rebuilt provide where technically possible pedestrian and bicycle facilities by adding sidewalks or pathways, or markings providing space for joggers and bicyclists to travel. Any improvements should include lighting and security measures.

1. Ensure that crossings and curbs throughout Claremont are ADA complaint.
2. Use directional and warning signs which promote these forms of transportation on and off city streets.
3. Look for opportunities to develop walking trails along the Sugar River and on City- owned property making sure that any new trails consider the installation of benches and adequate lighting.
4. Install secure bicycle racks at frequently visited places, including places where regional public transit is provided. Ensure that bike racks are aesthetically pleasing and usable year-round.
5. Advocate for the installation of a seasonal boat dock to improve the utility of the Connecticut River launch site.
6. Create a policy for the safe use of recreational vehicles and coordinate with the State of New Hampshire, when necessary.
7. Include provisions for bicycle travel in future land use regulation updates.
8. Set policy for use of watershed areas for hiking and recreational vehicles.
9. Continue the efforts of the Conservation Commission to complete the Rail Trail Master Plan and if needed identify alternative routes for All-Terrain Vehicle(ATV) use.

Goal 4. Provide for a walkable and bikeable community.

1. Build sidewalks on at least one side of every City street within the developed portion of the community and include connections/crosswalks for continuous network with a priority on streets within a one-mile radius of public schools.
2. Promote active student transportation opportunities like walking school bus or bike train programs for student commutes to and from schools.
3. Ensure that streets leading to school bus stops have sidewalks.
4. Provide sidewalks and bicycle routes between City parks.
5. Require new development to provide for sidewalks either through construction or an easement for future construction.



6. Consistently fund the repair and construction of sidewalks.
Develop a City-wide bicycle and pedestrian plan that can be gradually achieved by acquiring property, easements, and additional space on roads.
7. Seek state and federal funding for bicycle and pedestrian projects.
8. Improve pedestrian and crosswalk signage
9. Encourage crosswalk enforcement.
10. Achieve national recognition as a bicycle and walking friendly community.
11. Ensure that all newly built sidewalk and pedestrian amenities are ADA compliant and work to bring existing sidewalks into compliance.
12. Consider creating artistic sidewalks.
13. Review crosswalk locations to ensure they meet safety standards.
14. Remove utility poles from sidewalks when possible.

Goal 5. Incorporate Complete Streets Design into the Central Business District

Complete Streets is a philosophy that guides community, planning, and transportation agencies to consider and incorporate safe access to destinations for everyone, regardless of age or ability, or mode of transportation, when feasible.

Depending on the street that could translate into a wider sidewalk, bike lanes, safe crossing opportunities, bus lanes, median islands, roundabouts and more.

1. Pursue engineering design concepts and design study to redesign downtown streets to incorporate Complete Streets and improve character of downtown.
2. Develop a Complete Streets policy to be followed on streets in the Mixed-Use District.
3. Use traffic calming techniques such as narrowing the roadway for crosswalks to improve pedestrian safety. (See Figure 8-1)
4. Eliminate parking spaces and other obstructions near intersections which block the



**Example of integrating traffic calming
and pedestrian safety**

line of sight drivers have for oncoming traffic. Amend the City's land use regulations to maintain safe sight distance.

5. Develop a committee to review the truck route studies completed to date and identify solutions for implementation.

At pedestrian crossings, particularly near schools, roadways can be narrowed to shorten the crossing distance and prevent vehicles from passing on the right side of the street which endangers pedestrians. (Source: FHWA – Traffic Calming Primer)

Goal 6. Improve public transportation resources.

1. Identify and maintain commuter parking areas for park and ride commuters who car pool or use transit for commuting.
2. Evaluate the need to build and maintain shelters for people waiting to use public transportation.
3. Provide shuttle service from commuter parking areas to the central business district to ease the downtown parking demand, including River Valley Community College.
4. Support regional bus service and the Route 120 corridor transit service. Expand the public transit system to meet employer/employee demand, particularly to and from River Road.
5. Consult regularly with private and governmental groups interested in public transit.
6. Investigate ways to contribute financially for the development of mass transit.
7. Evaluate the feasibility of a transit connection between downtown Claremont and the Weathersfield Park & Ride.

Goal 7. Improve traffic flow on main retail and business corridors, including Washington Street and Charlestown Road.

1. Develop road network redundancy so that accidents or blockages along Washington Street, particularly in the vicinity of the North Street and Winter Street intersections, do not impede emergency service to or from the hospital.
2. Create zoning and planning provisions that reduce curb cuts along major roadways such as common entrances for several businesses on parcels which may have separate ownership. Careful consideration and assessment of future development should be taken to mitigate and limit negative impacts to road safety.
3. Approve zoning and planning measures that require or create parallel back street connections to improve roadway network connectivity.
4. Apply policies for traffic on Washington Street to other areas of heavy commercial development such as Charlestown Road and North Street.
5. Conduct periodic corridor studies of principal routes throughout the City.



6. Improve the linkage of the Bobby Woodman Rail Trail to Washington Street to provide access to the pedestrian amenities the rail trail provides.
7. Implement the Washington Street safety study. See Appendix 1.

Goal 8. Steadily improve the roadways in Claremont.

1. Develop a Complete Streets policy to be implemented City wide.
2. Consistently fund the rebuilding and repaving of roads.
3. Create a pavement management program including a system to prioritize most important byways are maintained first and the ones in the worst condition, but less often used, are maintained secondarily. Explore the utilization of a Road Surface Management System (RSMS) to accomplish this task.
4. Ensure that new road and sidewalk construction meet the City code requirements before they are accepted by the City.
5. Acquire property or easements so that when funding becomes available for improvements to the transportation network the City can act.
6. Do design work so that projects are “shovel ready” in case funding becomes available.
7. Continue to improve the Route 103 roadway to facilitate east-west traffic.
8. Continue to participate in the Upper Valley Lake Sunapee Regional Planning Commission’s Transportation Advisory Committee, which plans for improvements on a regional basis.
9. Communicate with elected local officials and state representatives about City and regional transportation needs in order to get necessary planning and funding.
10. Communicate to the state DOT the City’s fiscal constraints and transportation needs for long-term improvement.
11. The Traffic Advisory Committee (TAC) should review accident statistics so that dangerous intersections can be identified and improved. In addition, TAC should review when roads are added or improved.
12. Make aesthetically pleasing improvements to the transportation system.
13. Work with NHDOT to improve River Road (Route 12A) to include shoulders to better accommodate emergency situations, bicycles, pedestrians, line of sight, and increased truck traffic.
14. Review standards for roads in ordinances to ensure they are appropriate.
15. Implement a maintenance program to bring City road signs in conformance with the Manual of Uniform Traffic Control Devices.
16. Work with the NHDOT preventative maintenance program for bridges.
17. Pursue the reconstruction of Main Street from Elm Street to Citizen Street utilizing Complete Streets design.

Goal 9. Apply for grants that support this chapter.

Conclusion

Claremont's consistent, innovative and proactive attention to the transportation system will make our community a better place to live, work and play. That outcome will more likely ensure achieving our goals of a desirable quality of life and economic success. Additionally, it will provide a safe and welcoming environment to visitors and tourists enjoying all that Claremont has to offer.

Appendices:

The following appendices have not been included in this printing. Digital copies are available online:

Table A: Traffic Count History for Roads (2008-2015)

http://www.claremontnh.com/MP2017/Transportation_TableA.pdf

Table B: Roads and Intersections in Critical Need of Service

http://www.claremontnh.com/MP2017/Transportation_TableB.pdf

Appendix A: Washington Street Safety Study

http://www.claremontnh.com/MP2017/Transportation_AppA.pdf